
Isla and the Star That Knew Her Name
A bedtime story for Isla

“Happy fifth birthday, darling. We are so proud of you.”

With love from Grandma and Grandpa



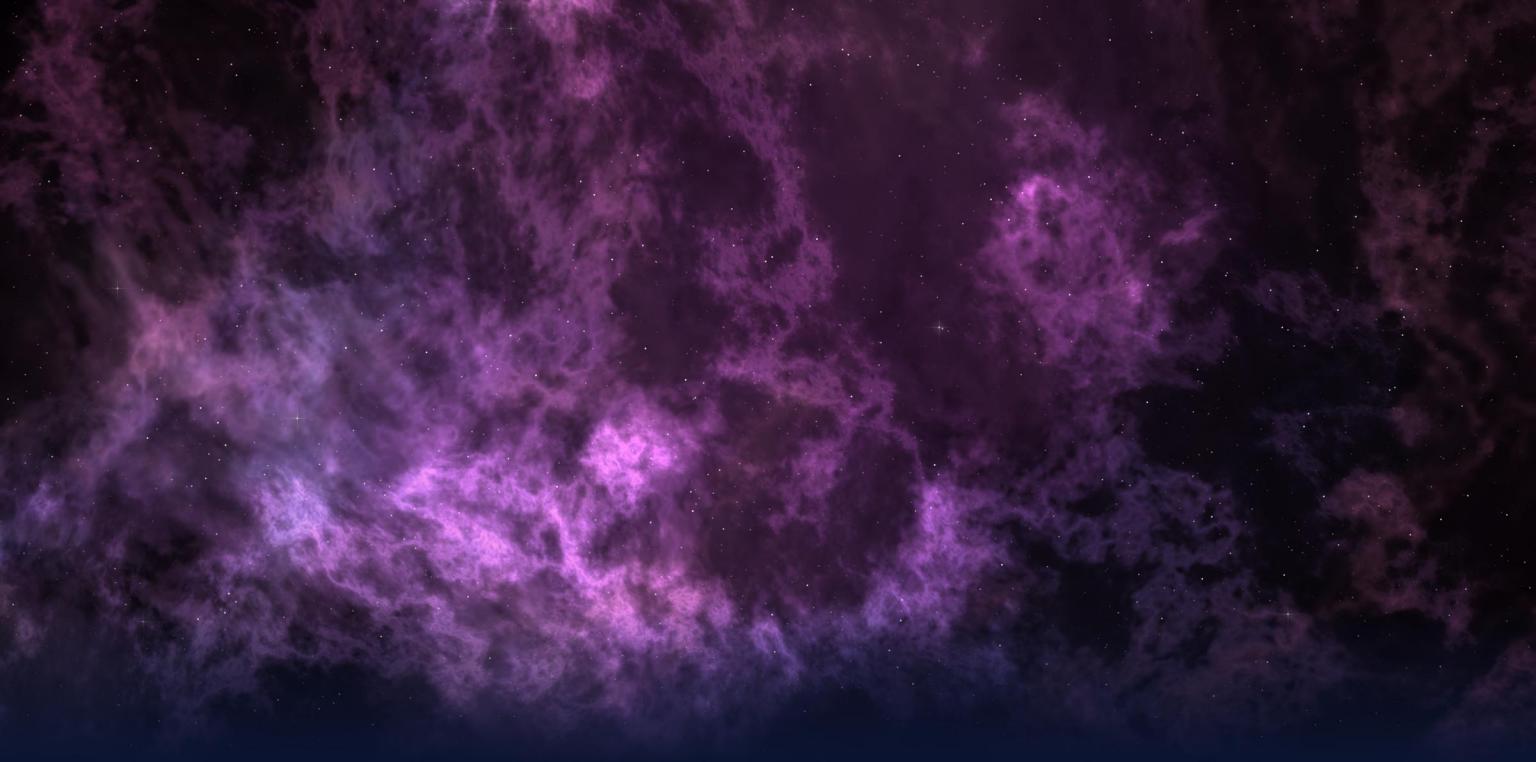
This is a story for Isla. It was the night after Isla's fifth birthday. The cake was eaten, the wrapping paper was folded away, and the house had gone soft and quiet. Isla was snuggled up in bed. So let's get cosy too. Let your shoulders sink into the pillow. Breathe in slowly, and breathe out. One more time. In, and out. Outside the window, a single star began to glow, brighter and brighter, until it was looking straight at Isla. "Hello, Isla," whispered the star, in a voice like a tiny silver bell. "I've been waiting for you."



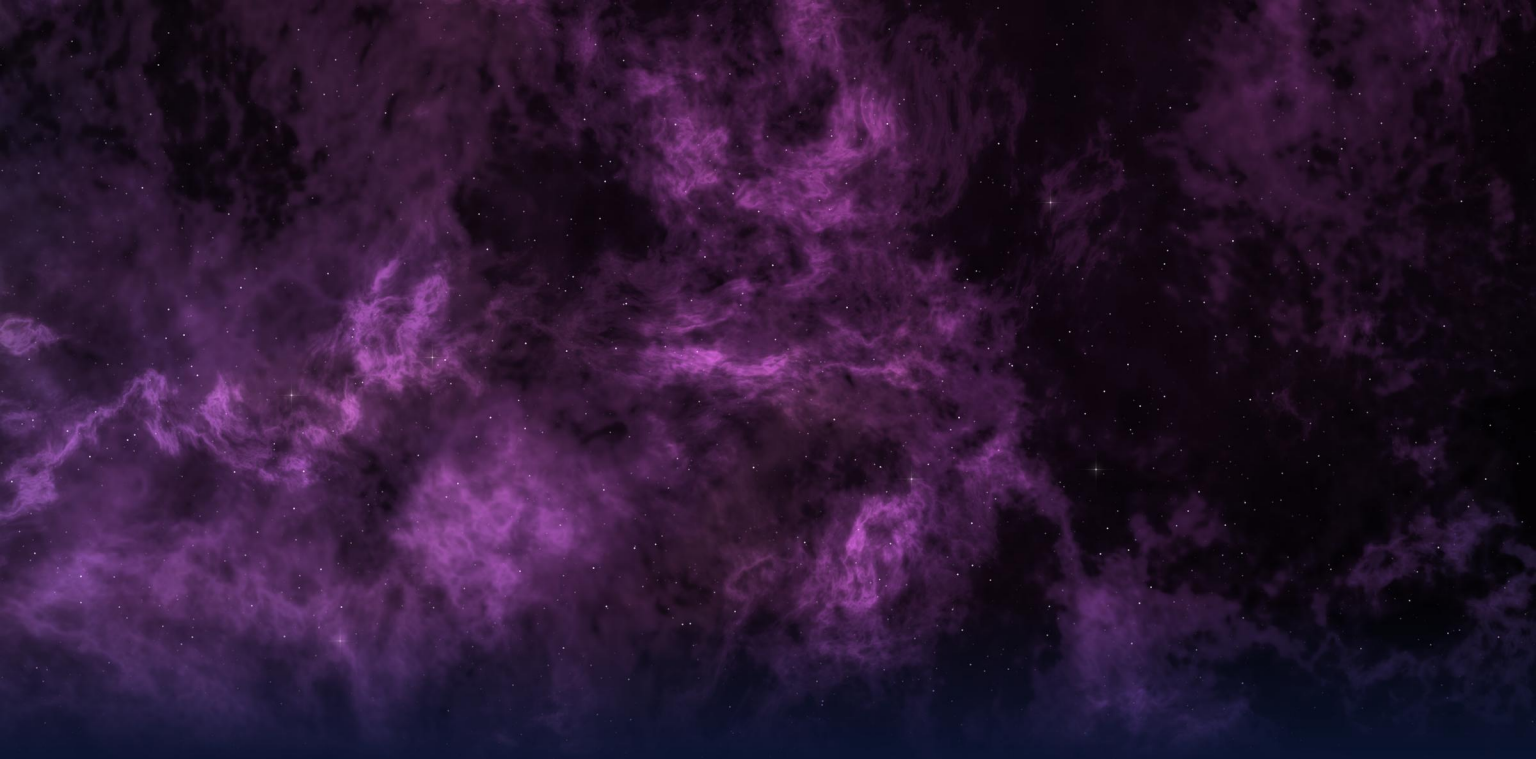
"I was there on the night you were born," said the star. "It was Sunday, the second of May, twenty twenty-one. The Moon was a waning gibbous moon that night, and I was shining right above you, in the stars of Ursa Major. I've been watching over you ever since." Then something padded softly across the windowsill. It was a bunny, a little bunny made entirely of starlight, glowing gently, with eyes like two tiny moons. "I'm here to keep you company," said the bunny. "Hold on to me, and don't worry. We'll be back before you know it."



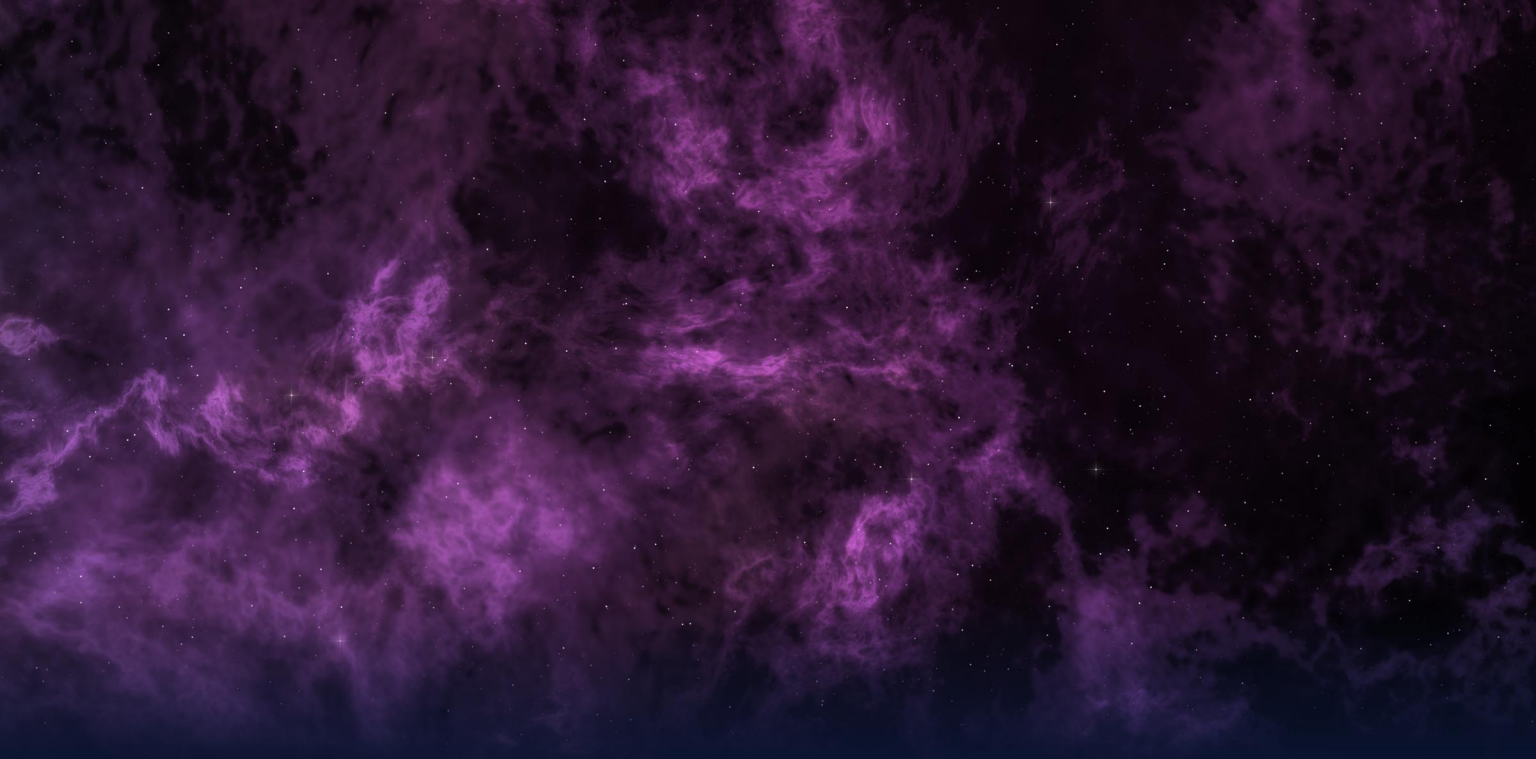
A moonbeam slid down through the window, as smooth and silver as a ribbon. Isla and the starlight bunny climbed onto it, and it lifted them up, up past the rooftops, up past the clouds, up into the deep, quiet blue of the night. They floated past the planets that had been out on the night Isla was born. Little Mercury, hurrying round the Sun as fast as it could. Rusty red Mars, with its tall sleepy volcanoes. The bunny waved a glowing paw at each one, and each one seemed to glow back.



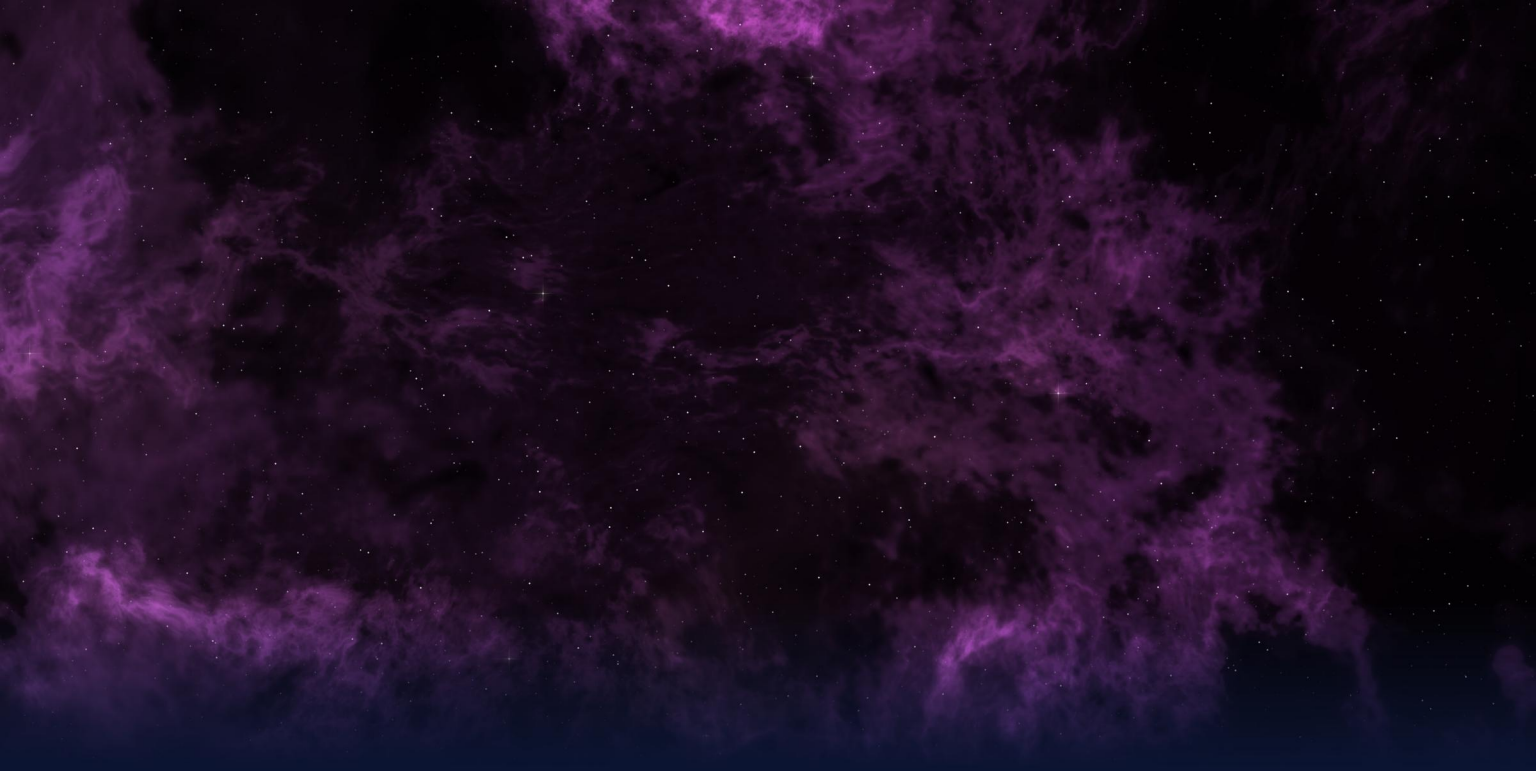
And then, ahead of them, the darkness began to glow. Great soft clouds of purple and lilac and the softest blue stretched further than Isla could see, curling and drifting like steam from a warm drink. "This is your nebula," said the star. "Isla's Nebula. It's a place where new stars are born, just like you were born. No one else in the whole universe has one quite like it." Isla reached out a hand, and the cloud felt like the softest blanket in the world. Tiny new stars were blinking awake inside it, one, and then another, and then another, like fireflies on a summer evening.



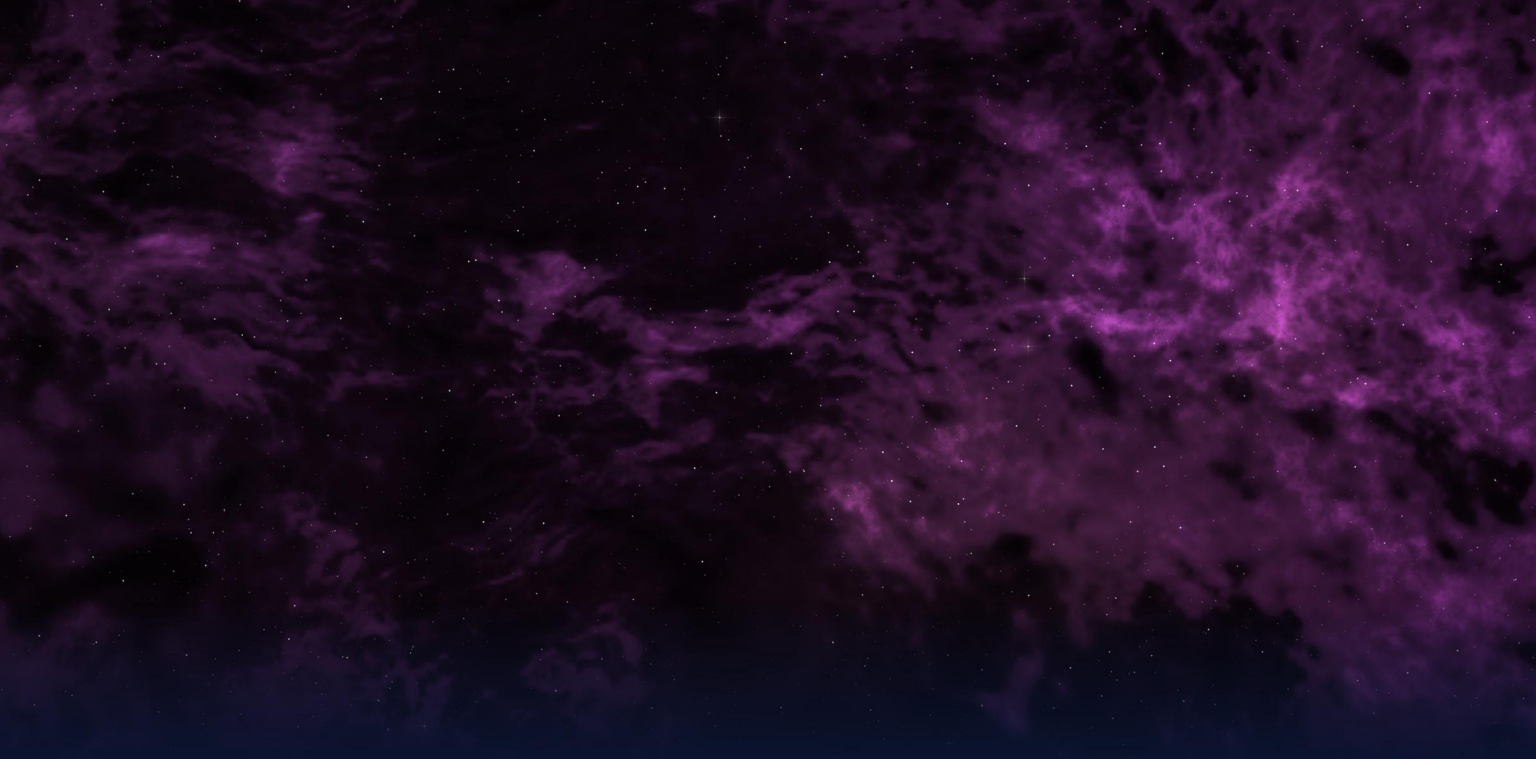
"We have a birthday present for you," said the star. "Five wishes, one for every year." The first little star floated down and whispered a wish for sweet dreams, every single night. The second little star floated down and whispered a wish for courage, the quiet kind that lets you try new things. The third little star floated down and whispered a wish for love, more than all the stars put together. The fourth little star floated down and whispered a wish for curiosity, so that you never stop asking why. The fifth little star floated down and whispered a wish for laughter, the sort that makes your tummy ache in the best way.



Each wish landed on Isla as softly as a snowflake, and stayed. Then the star said, "Someone asked me to give you a message. It's from Grandma and Grandpa." And in a voice as soft as a hug, the star said: "Happy fifth birthday, darling. We are so proud of you." By now, Isla's eyes were getting heavy. The starlight bunny gave a great big yawn. "Time to go home," it said. The moonbeam curled around them like a scarf, and down they floated, slowly, slowly, past the planets, past the clouds, all the way back to Isla's warm, cosy bed.



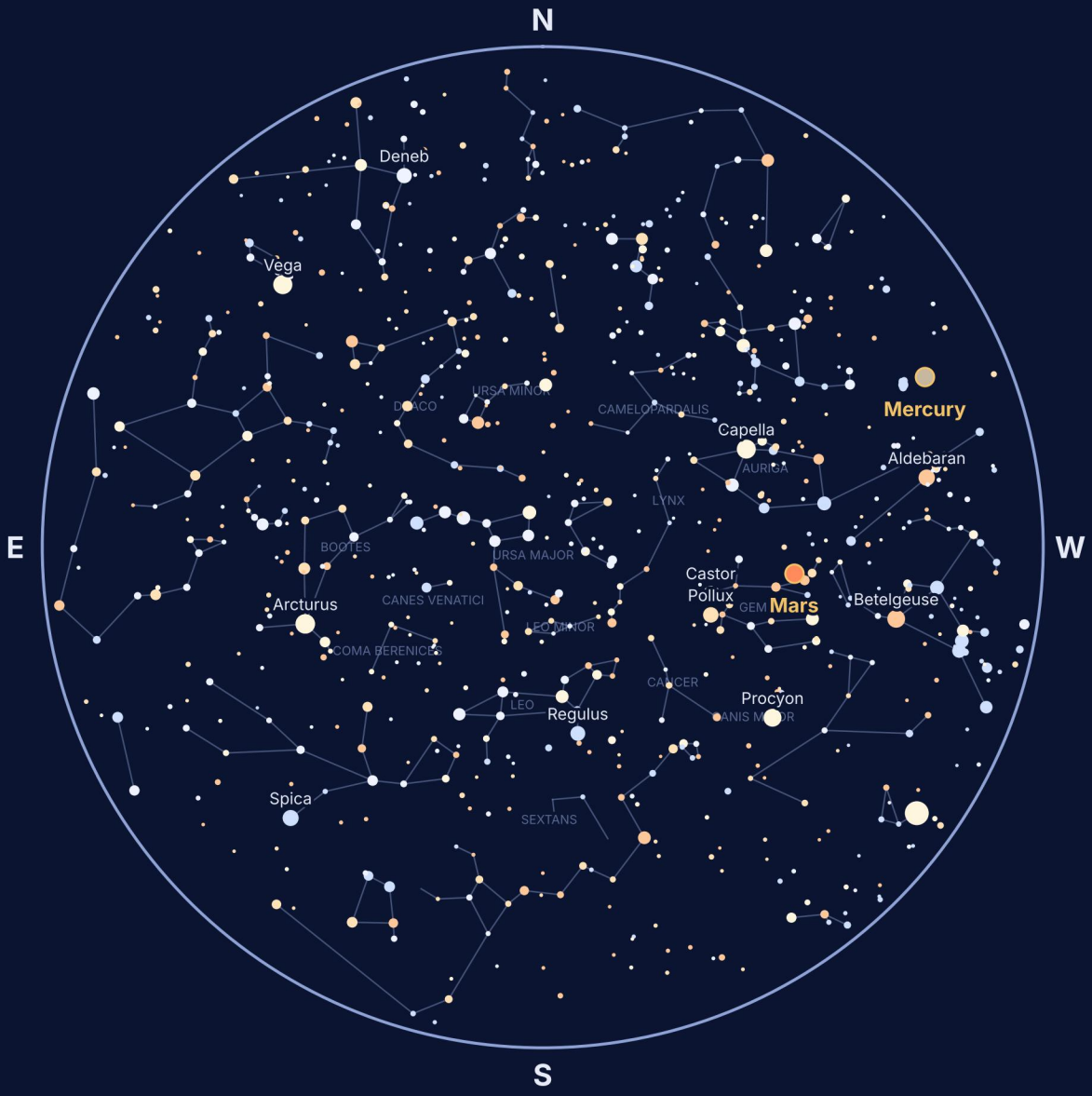
Let's count the stars down together, nice and slowly. Ten. Nine. Eight. Seven. Six. Five. Four. Three. Two. One. The starlight bunny curled up at the end of the bed, glowing softly, and slowly faded into a faint shimmer that only Isla would ever know was there. And outside the window, Isla's star kept watch, twinkling gently, the way it always had, and the way it always will. Here's a secret to keep. On the night you were born, the star called Arcturus was shining above you. The light from it had set off around nineteen eighty-four, and travelled all that way, just to reach you.



Goodnight, Isla. Sweet dreams. Your star is watching over you.

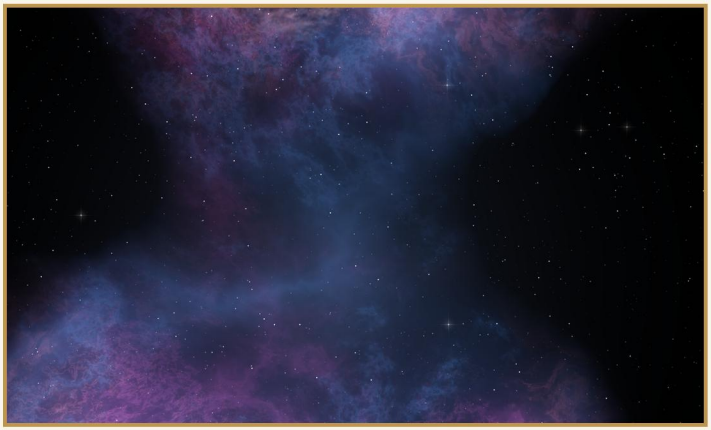
The sky on the night you were born

Leeds · 2 May 2021



Computed from the real positions of the Moon, planets and stars.

Certificate of a Nebula



This nebula was created especially for

Isla

Isla's Nebula · Five today

Under the real sky of Leeds, 2 May 2021

This is an original artwork made for one person. Its shapes and colours grow from the name it was made for, so no one else has one quite like it. It is a keepsake, not an official astronomical name.